

36% can't keep pace with their peer group

40% feel that they can not confide in their parents



Model: KHUSHI/www.indiatodayimages.com

children face one or more persisting problems (personal, academic or otherwise) to which they see no solution; 54 per cent find it necessary to take tuitions after school; 36 per cent find it difficult to keep pace with their peer group, not just in studies but in other activities, too. Add to that 47 per cent children whose days are too full of things to do (school, tuitions, family obligations) and 54 per cent who spend over a couple of hours each day commuting to school—and you get a peek into the life of urban Indian children. Mehta of AIIMS is not surprised, “Children are increasingly found to be defiant, hostile, irritable, quarrelsome and destructive these days,” she says.

That's exactly what the parents of a 13-year-old Chandigarh girl complained of when they brought her, comatose, to paediatrician, Dr R.S. Bedi. Barred from calling up two of her boyfriends at nights, harassed by spying siblings, bullied by family members for not doing well in school, disturbed and distraught, she had started taking sleeping pills and went into overkill that day. The doctor reprimanded the parents and referred the family to a counsellor. They never visited him again. “Teenage is the time for hormonal change. A lot of parents don't recognise that,” says Bedi. “Kids

don't feel at home when they are at home. When they come back from school, parents are away. At home parents are either too tired or too busy. Home is like a hostel these days,” he adds. No wonder, for 36 per cent of the surveyed children, home is not a refuge, 40 per cent can't confide in their parents, 16 per cent crave for love from extended family and 7 per cent are from broken homes.

Ahmedabad boy, Satyam Patel, 14, landed up in a hospital with an abysmal haemoglobin count of eight. It was just waiting to happen. The reed-thin student of class IX would skip breakfast, scarf down unhealthy fried food at school, hurry through lunch, slog at his all-subject coaching class in the afternoon and burn the midnight oil over his school and tuition homework. No one noticed when the drudgery started telling on him, until one day he fell sick. “Parental pressure to do well in life takes a huge toll on today's troubled children,” says city psychologist, Dr Prashant Bhimani. “Another thorny issue is a father's unwillingness to spend enough time with children,” he points out. With Bhimani's help, Satyam is well on his way to recovery.

Doctors across the country are pressing the panic button. Paediatrician, Dr Paresh Majmudar, who owns two

“A growing number show signs of psychological disorders. They are increasingly found to be defiant, irritable and destructive.”

**DR MANJU MEHTA**  
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**65% FACE PERSONAL, ACADEMIC OR FAMILY PROBLEMS, TO WHICH THEY SEE NO SOLUTION.**